reader IV

Maravilloso Reading Group

If we build politically by virtue of the vulnerability of our bodies, then we have to recognize the vulnerability of the body as something indisputable.

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El Inicio / The Beginning and selected quotes from Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia

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Things We Lost in the Fire by Mariana Enríquez

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Ballad of the Burned Man by Fernanda Melchor

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(....) we see it as critical to decenter the category of masculinity, understood as an intrinsic and exclusive property of male bodies. This de-centering would lead to a discursive, non-violent reconstruction able to multiply the array of possibilities for the construction of new subjectivities, both for women and men.

p. 289 (Butler)

This means that each of us is constructed politically in part by virtue of the social vulnerability of our bodies—as a site of desire and physical vulnerability, as a site of publicity at once assertive and exposed. Loss and vulnerability seem to follow from our being socially constituted bodies, attached to others, at risk of losing those attachments, exposed to others, at risk of violence by that exposure.

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The left needs to make alliances with a wide array of social movements. Besides examining its own theoretical motivations, it needs to map out the practical activities that might reshape it into a school of thought that grounds resistance in the specific context of the problems that develop in our contemporary societies.

Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia
[selected fragments]

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We know it is possible to unseat masculinity from its position in the gender hierarchy because it is a modifiable performative process on the part of men. This modification is imminent now that the capitalist world has become even more cruel and radically brutal, demanding that the surplus value of a product derive from bloodshed; right now, this system

> *'...fails to meet the needs of men [and when it does, it exacts a higher and higher price for it]—no more work, loss of dignity at work, absurdity and cruelty of economic constraint, administrative irritations, bureaucratic humiliations, knowing you'll be ripped off whenever you try to buy something, [escalating violence].' [Despentes]*

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We have to fight against the entrenched idea that crime pays, in other words, that violence and criminality are extremely profitable economic processes—even though in fact they are. We need to establish restrictions to allow for a more peaceful coexistence and emphasize the right to not be a victim of predatory violence in the pursuit of economic enrichment.

This transformation must occur through education at all levels, and principally through language, since we do everything with words; we need to bestow words with precise meanings in order to achieve "a minimum level of historical, ideological, and terminological coherence."

Esto es Tijuana

The fury of clouds that is the Pacific Ocean.

A dismembered torso strewn across the highway at rush hour. Cigarettes lit in rapid succession. The neon lights of the red-light district, microscopic universes. Arboreal metastasis.

Narcos. Machismo. Silicone Land. Whore-Barbie's Factory. High caliber weapons laughing, cackling. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Leaving and staying at the same time. Finding another way to say that everything is an eternal return. Irrevocable trajectories and irrevocable women. Violence, tedium and the everyday grind: overdrawn on all accounts. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The word *Bienvenidos* laughing in my face. The word *Bienvenidos* meaning every entrance is an exit. Silence stabs. The desert boils. Migrant screams ring out. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Donkey-zebras imitating nostalgia. Shiny new cars. Enraged taxis. The head repeats an atrocious mantra, "open (yourself) up on the inside." Get into the game. See the Fire. Escape constantly and once and for all bet on winning. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Where the questions where, when and why might not exist, the same as the word "never." Where half of the half does not compute. Where *Interminably* is the same as *Now.*

City of *over and over again.* Where the truth is never known. Where all words—including the word incest—portend multiple histories. Where *mi casa es su casa.* Where *su casa no es mi casa.* Where yes, actually, *su casa es mi caza*: I'm on a hunt and your house is my prey. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La línea never frees itself from the metallic serpent on either side.

A *frontera*-woman looks like death and walks with one hand on her revolver. The syringe-man unsuccessfully attempts to fly along the middle of the metal serpent. The transparent and the true. The piercing.

The first and the third world. The border. El bordo. Hell. The other part of the other side. The other side of the other side. The *This* side of the *Other* side. The happy world of disenchantment. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The limit. The perimeter. The edge of the world. He/she/they/what is dragged behind. The shore that licks white, middle-class, civilized culture and brings it to its end. The time bomb that detonates us. San Diego's garage.

The divided sea laughing raucously *entre las olas. Entre Las Solas.* In the waves and in all the women on their own. The grayness. The paradox. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The *copyright* of the end. *Cartel-right.* Gore capitalism. *Hotels, attractions, nightlife, restaurants, weather and border crossing...*

A blind search for combinatorics. Two million possibilities. *Crunchy, spicy and totally addictive-fabulous blends. Depictions of sodomy, bestiality, alternative sexual practices, racial and ethnic stereotypes. This is Tijuana.*

Everything that enters or leaves the city comes from two parts. Everything here leaves in two or more parts. *You can have whatever you can buy.* City of businesses. Virgin girls *for sale.* Affordable prices for foreigners. Luis Donaldo Colosio Acribillado (a.k.a Bullet-Riddled). Música de banda. Morgue. Techno. NAFTA. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La Tía Juana, Tiguana, Tiuana, Teguana, Tiwana, Tijuan, Ticuan, TJ, Tijuas: you can call her whatever you want because Tijuana—like every other word—means nothing and means: "beside the sea."

Esto es *Queerland.* "Aquí empieza la patria / The homeland begins here."

Esto es Tijuana.

At the brink of el bordo, I become blade.

Tijuana is affectionate. Unfathomable. Full of possibilities.

To be in love with a psychopath and to say so with a smile.

You should leave now. This is Tijuana.

The subway girl was first. Some people would dispute that, or at least they would deny that she had the power or influence to instigate the bonfires all alone. And all alone she was: the subway girl preached on the city's six underground train lines, and no one was ever with her. But she was unforgettable. Her face and arms had been completely disfigured by deep, extensive burns. She talked to the passengers about how long it had taken her to recover, about the months of infections, hospitals, and pain. Her mouth was lipless and her nose had been sloppily reconstructed. She had only one eye left—the other was a hollow of skin—and her whole face, head, and neck were a maroon mask crisscrossed by spiderwebs. On the nape of her neck she still had one lock of long hair left, which emphasized the masklike effect; it was the only part of her head the fire hadn't touched. Nor had it reached her hands, which were dark and always a little dirty from handling the money she begged for.

Her method was audacious: she got on the train, and if there weren't many passengers, if almost everyone had a seat, she greeted each of them with a kiss on the cheek. Some turned their faces away in disgust, even with a muffled shriek; others accepted the kiss and felt good about themselves; some just let the revulsion raise the hair on their arms, and if she saw this, in summer when people's skin was bare, she'd caress the scared little hairs with her grubby fingers and smile with her mouth that was a slash. Some people even got off the train if they saw her get on. They already knew her routine and wanted to avoid the kiss from that horrible face.

To make matters worse, the subway girl wore tight jeans, see-through blouses, even high-heeled sandals when it was hot out. She wore bracelets on her wrists, and little gold necklaces hung around her neck. For her to flaunt a sensuous body seemed inexplicably offensive.

When she begged for money she was very clear: she wasn't saving up for plastic surgery. There was no use, she would never get her normal face back, and she knew it. She only needed money to cover her expenses, for rent, for food—no one would give her work with a face like that, not even in jobs where the public wouldn't see her. And always, when she finished telling her audience about her days in the hospital, she named the man who had burned her: Juan Martín Pozzi, her husband. She'd been married to him for three years. They had no children. He thought she was cheating on him and he was right—she'd been about to leave him. To keep that from happening, he ruined her. Decided she would belong to no one else. While she was sleeping, he poured alcohol over her face and held a lighter to it. While she couldn't talk, when she was in the hospital and everyone was expecting her to die, Pozzi claimed she'd burned herself, that she'd spilled alcohol during a fight and then tried to smoke a cigarette, still wet.

"And they believed him." The subway girl smiled with her lipless, reptilian mouth. "Even my father believed him."

As soon as she could talk, still recovering in the hospital, she told the truth. Now he was in jail.

When the burned girl left the subway car no one talked about her, but the silence that was left, broken by the shaking as the train moved over the rails, said, *How disgusting, how frightening, I'll never forget her, how can someone live like that?*

Maybe it wasn't the subway girl who started it all, thought Silvina, *but she definitely introduced the idea in* my *family.* It had been a Sunday afternoon, and she and her mother were coming back from the movies—a rare excursion, since they almost never went out together. On the train, the subway girl got into their car, gave kisses to the passengers, and told her story. When she finished, she thanked everyone and got off at the next stop. The usual uncomfortable and ashamed silence didn't follow. A boy, who couldn't have been more than twenty years old, started saying, "How manipulative, how gross, how desperate." He also cracked jokes. Silvina remembered how her mother—tall, with short, gray hair, her whole aspect one of authority and power—had walked to the boy, crossing the aisle almost unwaveringly though the train shook as much as always. She'd drawn back her arm and punched the boy in the nose, a decisive and professional blow that made him bleed and cry out, "You old bitch, what's wrong with you?" But her mother didn't respond, not to the boy crying in pain nor to the other passengers, who weren't sure whether to berate her or come to her defense. Silvina remembered the quick look, the silent instruction in her mother's eyes, and how they'd both shot out of the train as soon as the doors opened, how they'd kept running up the stairs from the platform even though Silvina wasn't in good shape and she got tired right away—running made her cough—and her mother was over sixty years old. No one followed them, but they didn't realize it at first. On the busy corner of Corrientes and Pueyrredón they mixed in with the crowd to shake off any guards, or even police, but after two hundred meters they realized they were safe. Silvina couldn't forget her mother's elated laughter, so relieved. It had been years since she'd seen her so happy.

Still, it took Lucila and the epidemic she unleashed for the bonfires to start. Lucila was a model and she was very beautiful, but more than that she had a quirky charm about her. In TV interviews she seemed distracted and guileless, but she had intelligent and audacious things to say, and she became famous for that, too. Or half famous. True celebrity only came when

she announced she was dating Mario Ponte, number 7 on the Unidos de Córdoba team. They were a second-division club that had heroically made it to the first, and they'd remained among the best during two championships thanks to a great squad, but above all thanks to Mario, who was an extraordinary player. He had rejected offers from European clubs out of pure loyalty—although some commentators said that at thirty-two and with the level of competition in Europe, it was better for Mario to become a local legend than a transatlantic failure. Lucila seemed to be in love, and though the couple got a lot of media coverage, no one scrutinized them too closely. They were perfect and happy—quite simply, they lacked drama. She got better modeling contracts and closed out all the fashion shows; he bought himself a very expensive car.

Drama came one morning at dawn when they carried Lucila on a stretcher out of her and Mario's apartment: seventy percent of her body was burned, and they said she wouldn't survive. She survived a week.

Silvina vaguely remembered the news reports, the gossip around the office. He had burned her during a fight, they said. Just like with the subway girl, he'd poured a bottle of alcohol over her while she was in bed, and then he'd thrown a lit match onto her naked body. He let her burn a few minutes before covering her with the bedspread. Then he called the ambulance. Like the subway girl's husband, he claimed that she'd done it to herself.

That's why, when women started burning themselves for real, no one believed it at first, Silvina thought while she waited for the bus (she didn't use her own car to visit her mother, since she knew she could be followed). People preferred to believe those women were protecting their men, that they were still afraid of them, in shock and unable to tell the truth. The bonfires were just too hard to comprehend.

Now that there was another bonfire every week, no one knew what to say or how to stop them, except through the usual measures: inspections, police, surveillance. None of it worked. Once, an anorexic friend of Silvina's had told her, "They can't force you to eat."

"Yes, they can," Silvina answered, "they can feed you intravenously, through a tube."

"Yes, but they can't watch you all the time. You cut the tube. You cut off the fluid. No one can watch you twenty-four hours a day. People sleep." It was true. That high school classmate had ended up dying. Silvina sat down with her backpack on her lap. She was glad she didn't have to stand during the ride. She was always afraid a thief would open her backpack and find out what she was carrying.

A LOT OF WOMEN WERE BURNED before the bonfires began. It was contagious, explained the experts in domestic violence, in newspapers and magazines and on radio and television, anywhere they could pontificate. It was a complex subject to report on, they said, because on one hand it was necessary to sound the alarm about the femicides, and on the other hand the reports had a ripple effect, similar to what happens among teenagers with suicide. Men were burning their girlfriends, wives, lovers, all over the country. Most of the time they used alcohol, like Ponte (he had already been a hero to so many), but they also used acid, and in one particularly horrible case a woman had been thrown onto a pile of burning tires, part of some worker protest, in the middle of the highway. But Silvina and her mother only mobilized—singly, without consulting one another—after what happened to Lorena Pérez and her daughter, the last murders before the first bonfires. The father, before killing himself, had set fire to mother and daughter with the now tried-and-true bottle of alcohol. They didn't know the victims, but Silvina and her mother both went to the hospital to try to visit them, or to at least protest outside; they ran into each other there. And the subway girl was there too.

But she wasn't alone, not anymore. Now she was accompanied by a group of women of various ages, none of them burned. When the cameras arrived, the subway girl and her companions moved into the spotlight. She told her story, and the others nodded and shouted encouragement. Then the subway girl said something dreadful, brutal:

"If they go on like this, men are going to have to get used to us. Soon most women are going to look like me, if they don't die. And wouldn't that be nice? A new kind of beauty."

Once the cameras had gone, Silvina's mother approached the subway girl and her companions. Several of the women were over sixty years old, and Silvina was surprised to see them so willing to spend the night in the street, to camp out on the sidewalk and paint their signs saying *WE WILL BE BURNED NO MORE.* Silvina stayed with them too, and in the morning she went to the office without having slept. Her coworkers hadn't even heard about the burning of the mother and daughter. They're getting used to it, thought Silvina. The fact that the girl is a child makes the case a little more horrible, but only a little. She spent the morning sending messages to her mother, who didn't answer a single one. She was pretty bad about texting, so Silvina didn't worry. At night, she called her at home and couldn't reach her there either. Was she still at the hospital? Silvina went to look, but the women had abandoned their camp. All that remained were a few scattered markers and some empty snack wrappers swirling in the wind. There was a storm brewing, and Silvina rushed home as fast as she could because she'd left the windows open.

The girl and her mother had died during the night.

SILVINA'S FIRST BONFIRE had taken place in a field off Route 3. The security measures were still very basic then—those of the authorities and of the Burning Women. Many people still refused to believe. True, the case of the woman who'd burned in her own car out in the Patagonian desert had been very strange. The preliminary investigations showed that she'd poured gasoline on the car and then gotten in behind the wheel, and that she'd sparked the lighter herself. No one else: there were no tracks from any other car and it would have been impossible to hide them in the desert, and no one would have been able to get there on foot. A suicide, they said, a very strange suicide. The poor girl must have gotten the idea from all those burned women. We don't know why these attacks are happening in Argentina. These things belong in Arab countries, in India.

"They're some real sons of bitches, Silvinita, dear. Have a seat," said María Helena, her mother's friend and the head of a secret hospital for the burned. She had established it far from the city in the shell of her family's old estate, surrounded by cows and soy. "I don't know why that girl did what she did instead of getting in touch with us, but fine, maybe she wanted to die. That was her right. But these sons of bitches who say that burnings are for Arabs or Indians . . ."

María Helena dried her hands—she'd been peeling peaches for a cake—and looked Silvina in the eye.

"Burnings are the work of men. They have always burned us. Now we are burning ourselves. But we're not going to die; we're going to flaunt our scars."

The cake was in honor of one of the Burning Women, who had survived her first year. Some of those who went to the bonfires chose to recuperate in regular hospitals, but many preferred secret centers like María Helena's. There were others like it, Silvina wasn't sure how many.

"The problem is that they don't believe us. We tell them that we burn ourselves because we want to, but they don't believe us. Of course, we can't make the girls who are staying here talk; we might go to jail."

"We could film a ceremony," said Silvina.

"We thought about that, but it would invade the girl's privacy."

"Right, but what if one of them wanted it to be seen? And we could ask her to go toward the bonfire with, I don't know, a mask, a disguise, if she wants to cover her face."

"What if they can tell where the place is?"

"Oh, María, the pampa all looks the same. If we have the ceremony out in the grasslands, how will they know where it is?"

And, almost without thinking about it, Silvina volunteered to take charge of the filming if one of the girls ever wanted her Burn to go public. María Helena got in touch with her less than a month after she offered. She would be the only one in the ceremony authorized to have electronic equipment. Silvina arrived by car—back then, it was still fairly safe. Route 3 was almost deserted, only a few trucks out on the road. She could listen to music and try not to think: not about her mother, who was in charge of another clandestine hospital in an enormous house in the southern part of Buenos Aires. Her mother, always so fearless and bold, much more so than Silvina, who went on working at the office and still couldn't get up the nerve to join the women. Or about her father, dead since she was a little girl, a good and somewhat inept man. ("Don't ever think I'm doing this because of your father," her mother said to her once, on a break outside the makeshift hospital, while she was inspecting the antibiotics Silvina had brought her. "Your father was a delicious man, he never made me suffer.") Or about her ex-boyfriend, with whom she'd ended things once she realized her mother's radicalization was definitive, because she knew he would inevitably pose a danger to them. Or about whether she should betray the organization herself, tear it apart from within. Since when did people have a right to burn themselves alive? Why did she have to respect these women's wishes?

The ceremony took place at dusk. Silvina used the video function on a regular camera; phones were forbidden, she didn't have a camcorder, and she didn't want to buy one in case it could be traced. She filmed everything: the women preparing the pyre with enormous dry branches from trees in the countryside, the fire fed with newspapers and gas until the flames stood over a meter high. They were out in the backcountry, and a grove of trees and the house shielded the ceremony from the highway. The other road, to the right, was too far away for anyone to see them. There were no neighbors or workmen. Not at that hour. When the sun set, the chosen woman walked toward the fire. She walked slowly. Silvina thought the girl was going to change her mind because she cried the whole time. She had chosen a song for her ceremony, which the others—around ten, not many—were singing: "Your body, to the fire it goes / consumed quickly, devoured untouched." But she didn't change her mind. The woman entered the fire as if it were a swimming pool; she dove in, ready to sink. There was no doubt she did it of her own will. A superstitious or provoked will, but her own. She burned for barely twenty seconds. Then two women in asbestos suits dragged her out of the flames and carried her at a run to the hospital. Silvina stopped filming before the building came into view.

That night she put the video online. By the next day, millions of people had seen it.

SO SILVINA TOOK THE BUS. Her mother was no longer the head of the clandestine hospital on the city's south side. She'd had to move when the secret of the century-old stone house, formerly an old folks' home, had been discovered by one woman's

enraged parents ("She has children! She has children!" they'd screamed). Her mother had managed to escape the raid. She'd been tipped off by a neighbor who was a collaborator of the Burning Women, an activist who kept her distance, like Silvina. They had reassigned Silvina's mother to a secret clinic in Belgrano—after an entire year of raids, they'd decided the city was safer than secluded locations. María Helena's hospital had fallen too, though they never discovered the estate had been a location for the bonfires. Out in the country there's nothing more common than burning fields or leaves, so there would always be scorched grass and earth out there.

The judges expedited orders for raids, and in spite of the protests, women who didn't have families or who were simply out alone in public fell under suspicion. The police would make them open their purses, their backpacks, the trunks of their cars, anytime and anywhere. The harassment was getting worse lately, because the bonfires had escalated. In the beginning there'd been one every five months, and now there was a bonfire a week. And those were just the burnings on record, the ones where the women went to a public hospital.

And, just like that high school classmate of Silvina's, the women managed to elude the surveillance remarkably well. The countryside was still vast, and couldn't be monitored by satellite: plus, everyone has a price. If tons of drugs could be smuggled into the country, how were the authorities not going to let the occasional car pass with more drums of gasoline than was strictly reasonable? That was the only thing they needed, because the branches for the bonfires were already there, at every site. And the women brought their desire with them.

"It's not going to stop," the subway girl said in a TV interview. "Look on the bright side," she laughed with her reptile mouth. "At least there's no more prostitution. No one wants a burned monster, or a crazy Argentine woman who could go off one day and set herself on fire—she could burn the customer too."

ONE NIGHT, WHEN SILVINA WAS WAITING for her mother to call about another delivery of antibiotics (she'd have to collect them from the Burning Women collaborators who worked in the city's hospitals), she was struck by a sudden desire to talk with her ex-boyfriend. Her mouth was full of whiskey and her nose of cigarette smoke and the smell of sterilized gauze, the kind used for burns. It was a smell that never left her, along with that of burned human flesh, so difficult to describe. Mostly it smelled of gasoline, only with something more behind it, something unforgettable and strangely warm. But Silvina stopped herself from calling him. She'd seen him on the street with another girl. These days, of course, that didn't mean much. Many women tried not to be alone in public now so the police wouldn't bother them. Everything was different since the bonfires started. Just a few weeks earlier, the first survivors had started to show themselves. To take the bus. Go shopping at the supermarket. To take taxis and subways, open bank accounts, and enjoy a cup of coffee on the terraces of bars, their horrible faces lit by the afternoon sun, their hands—sometimes missing fingers—cupped around mugs. Would they find work? When would the longed-for world of men and monsters come?

Silvina and her mother visited María Helena in jail. At first they'd been afraid that the other inmates would attack her, but no, they treated her remarkably well. "It's because I talk with the girls here. I tell them that we women have always been burned—they burned us for four centuries! The girls can't believe it, they didn't know anything about the witch trials, isn't it incredible? Education in this country has gone to shit. But they're interested, they want to learn."

"What do they want to learn?" asked Silvina.

"Well, they want to know when the bonfires are going to stop."

"And when *are* they going to stop?"

"Oh, what do I know, child. If I had my way they'd never stop!"

The jail's visiting room was a big open hall with many tables, each with three chairs: one for the prisoner, two for visitors. María Helena spoke in a low voice. She didn't trust the guards.

"Some girls say they're going to stop when they reach the number of witches hunted during the Inquisition."

"That's a lot," said Silvina.

"It depends," interrupted her mother. "Some historians say it was hundreds of thousands, others only forty thousand."

"Forty thousand is a lot," murmured Silvina.

"Over four centuries it's not that many," her mother said.

"There weren't many people in Europe six centuries ago, Mom."

Silvina felt the fury fill her eyes with tears. María Helena opened her mouth and said something else but Silvina didn't hear it, and her mother went on and the two women conversed in the sickly light of the prison visitors' room and Silvina heard only how the two of them were too old, they wouldn't survive a Burn, the infection would carry them off in a second. But Silvinita, oh, when Silvina burned it would be beautiful, she'd be a true flower of fire.

Before she worked at Esther's house, Acilde sucked dicks at El Mirador, without ever taking off her clothes, under which her body – with its small breasts and narrow hips – passed for that of a fifteen-year-old boy. She had a regular clientele, mostly married men, sixtyish, whose dicks only perked up in a pretty boy's mouth. She'd usually wear a polo shirt a size too big so she'd look even younger and, rather than assiduously pacing the block like her colleagues, she'd sit on a bench under an orange streetlight pretending to read a comic. The more disinterested she made her boyish self seem, the more clients she had. Sometimes she took such great pains to come off like a schoolboy out for fresh air, just leaning back on the bench, her legs crossed with a foot on her knee, that she'd forget what she was there for until a booming car horn brought her back to El Mirador and the desperate men checking her out from behind the windows of their BMWs.

This was how she'd met Eric, Esther's right-hand man, and shaken him up. A Cuban doctor with movie-star good looks, Eric didn't need to pay for sex but he was crazy about those middle-class white boys who sold themselves so they could buy the pills they were addicted to. That night in the presidential suite – what they called the patch between the bushes where the grass was softest – Acilde sucked him and let him grab her head. Eric touched her hairless cheeks and pumped them with cum, recovering his erection almost immediately. "Get naked cuz I'm gonna stick it in you," he ordered, while Acilde spit to the side, brushed off the knees of her Levis with both hands, and asked for the five thousand pesos the blow job was worth. "I wanna screw you," Eric said, jerking off as the car lights raced over his chest and belly. Acilde hadn't quite finished saying "gimme my money, faggot" when Eric launched himself on top of her, immobilizing her, face down, and stifling her screams of "I'm a girl, shithead" with the gravel stuffed in her mouth. At this point, Eric didn't care what she was and just shoved his dry dick up her ass. When he finished and Acilde stood to pull up her pants, he flicked a lighter and approached her to confirm it was true that she was a woman. "I'm gonna pay you more for the special effects," he said. And when she saw how much more, she accepted his invitation to breakfast.

All the flimsy fried food stands the 2024 tidal wave had washed away from the Malecón reappeared in Mirador Park like flies buzzing. This new sea wall, just off a beach contaminated by unsalvageable corpses and sunken junk, felt like an oasis compared to some of the neighborhoods higher up, where the collectors pursued not only their usual targets but also the homeless, the mentally ill, and the prostitutes. She and Eric sat on plastic chairs under a colorful umbrella and ordered tostones and pork sausages. "There's nothing worse than a junkie faggot," Acilde told Eric as she swallowed the food she'd barely chewed. "They throw away their money, because mommy and daddy earn it for them, but not me. I want to study to be a chef, to cook in a fine restaurant, and save enough to get these cut off."

She was touching her breasts with both hands while Eric, now aware of their existence, thought they looked like bee stings under her T-shirt. "I can get you a better job than that, with someone who'll need you," he said.

"I don't want a husband to keep me," Acilde responded, and wiped her mouth with her sleeve.

Eric explained the deal: "It's this old santera, a friend of the president's, who needs somebody like you, young, quick, who'll cook for her and clean her house."

Acilde was perplexed. "Why would she want a dyke like me?"

Eric thought a few seconds before responding. "I can get her to pay for culinary school for you."

Acilde brought her index and middle fingers together to open her mail, then extended her ring finger, which Eric touched with his so he could see the file she wanted to share with him in his eye. It was an ad for an Italian cooking class, on sale that week, with the celebrity chef Chichi De Camps, with his chin and cashew-shaped nose, wearing an apron with his logo on it.

Acilde's room at Esther's was one of those typical rooms found in Santo Domingo's twentieth-century apartments, from when everybody had a servant who lived with them and, for a salary well below minimum wage, cleaned, cooked, washed, watched the kids, and attended to the clandestine sexual requirements of the men of the house. The explosive growth in telecommunications and factories in the Free Trade Zone had created new jobs for these women who had fled their bondage, one by one. Now, these service rooms – as they were called – were used for storage or as offices.

This job had come like a gift from heaven. Her rounds up at El Mirador had barely paid for food and data, without which she couldn't live. During her turns up there, she'd switch on the PriceSpy to check out the brands and prices of her clients' wardrobes, charging them for her services with that in mind. For her working hours, she'd prep a playlist that always ended with ABBA's "Gimme! Gimme! Gimme!" At the end of the night, she'd challenge herself to find a client, service him, and get paid before the live version of the song was over. When she did it, she'd reward herself with a plate of four-cheese ravioli at El Cappuccino, a trattoria a few blocks from the park. She'd order in the poor Italian she'd learned online during dead time at El Mirador and imagine whole conversations with the guys who ate at El Cappuccino every day, Italians in shoes that cost more than three digits and talked about business and soccer.

In her mind, one of them, a friend of her father's, recognized the resemblance. But that was pure bullshit. Her father had stayed by her mother's side just long enough to get her pregnant. Jennifer, her mother, a brunette with good hair who'd gone to Milan with a modeling contract, had gotten hooked on heroin and ended up selling her ass on the metro in Rome. She'd had six abortions when she decided

to go through with the seventh pregnancy, returning to her country so she could dump the baby on her parents, two bitter peasants from Moca who'd moved to the city after La Llorona and its two years of rain that had destroyed their homestead forever.

They beat Acilde for no reason, for being a tomboy, for wanting to play ball, for crying, for not crying. She'd compensate for the beatings at school with whoever glanced her way, and whenever she fought she'd lose track of time and a reddish light would fill her line of vision. In time, her knuckles swelled from the many scars forged from going against foreheads, noses, and walls. She had the hands of a man but that wasn't enough: she wanted the rest.

Her family detested her masculine ways. Her grandfather, César, decided to cure his granddaughter and brought over a young neighbor to see to her while he and her grandmother held her down and an aunt covered her mouth. That same night, Acilde ran away from home. She asked Peri, the class queer, if she could sleep at his place, a studio in Roberto Pastoriza, like the kind Peri's mom, Doña Bianca, rented out to students in town. The day of the tidal wave, Acilde went down to El Mirador, along with thousands of others who were curious or who'd managed to escape still in their pajamas, to see how that terrible wave swallowed her grandparents in their smelly little apartment in the Cacique.

Peri knew entire dialogues from twentieth-century comedies no one had seen, like *Police Academy* and *The Money Pit*. In these movies, Acilde could see the easy life of fifty years ago, and it surprised her that people lived without an integrated data plan or anything. Kids from well-off homes dropped in at Peri's to take pills and, sometimes for several days in a row, to play *The Giorgio Moroder Experience*. The Sony game let you go to a 1977 disco party and dance with other "fevers," what the kids who preferred war games used to call the millions who went to the virtual party, combining the trip with pills so they could surrender to the palpitating, sensual synthesizer of Donna Summer's "I Feel Love," which lasted a whole hour. By dawn, when the pills were gone as well as the money to buy them, Peri and his friend Morla would organize a stroll to El Mirador and, after a few hours of work, they'd come back for the second half of the party.

Morla was a kid from the neighborhood. He studied law and trafficked in whatever was available: fruit trees, those drugs that were still illegal, and marine creatures, a luxury coveted by wealthy collectors now that the three disasters had finished off practically every living thing under the sea. Morla's dream was to get a government job; he lied about his background in front of Peri's other friends, children of bureaucrats who looked down on him when, using their PriceSpys, they confirmed his Versace shirts were knockoffs. It was Morla who first talked to Acilde about Rainbow Brite, an injection making the rounds in alternative science circles that promised a complete sex change without surgery. The process had been compared to going cold turkey, although the homeless transsexuals who'd served as guinea pigs said it was much worse. In that instant, the fifteen thousand dollars needed for the drug became Acilde's only goal: she had to make that money. And since nothing better had occurred to her, that same night she went with Peri and Morla to El Mirador.

Now at Esther's, she dreamed of putting into practice what she'd learned in her cooking classes, paid for by Esther and Eric. At a restaurant in Piantini she would establish enough credit to ask for a loan and buy the wonderful vial. Her pastas drove the old woman crazy; she'd get up in the middle of the night for second helpings when she thought no one was looking. Since that terrible evening at her grandparents' house, Acilde suffered from insomnia and she'd stay up lifting weights and searching the internet for her alleged father's face. As she shaped her biceps, she'd enter the name of her progenitor into a search engine, looking for some resemblance: the wide chin or the thick eyebrows she'd inherited, which would serve her so well the day she managed to buy the drug. While searching these photos, her heart sped up, but then she'd imagine the brief email her circumstances would allow: "Hi, did you fuck a Dominican prostitute in 2008?" After her workout, she'd go to the kitchen and swallow the protein her muscles needed to grow, scaring the life out of the old woman as she ate directly out of a Tupperware container, bent in front of the freezer's open door. They'd make coffee, which they'd sip sitting together at the little kitchen table, and then Esther would tell her stories about her life and her religious vocation.

Esther Escudero was born in the seventies, during Joaquín Balaguer's twelve bloody years in power. "Almost as bloody as now," Esther would say without lifting her eyes from her cup, ashamed of being so close to a regime the foreign press – still – did not dare call a dictatorship. "In 2004, I was thirty years old and I fell in love with my boss. I used to edit her investigative TV show on Channel 4; she was married and had a kid. Her husband wanted to kill us. I'd lived my whole life denying the things I saw and felt. It seems the husband paid for someone to put a curse on me, black magic, so I had my period nonstop. I thought I was going to die. I was already hospitalized when, one day, the woman who had been my nanny when I was a baby showed up, a woman called Bélgica, who never took off the purple handkerchief she wore on her head. She leaned down, mouth stinking of nicotine. 'We're going to Cuba,' she said. I told her she was nuts, with what money?, but she had everything ready to go. She was a poor black woman from the countryside and I couldn't understand a thing but I was so alone and so weak I let her convince me. It turns out my grandmother's family had her things and Bélgica had promised to make sure I followed in her tradition. In Matanzas I met my padrino, Belarminio Brito, Omidina, child of Yemayá, and he was so bad, as noxious as gas. But he consecrated me and returned me to life. As soon as I entered his saint's room, I stopped bleeding. Look, my hairs are standing on end. That man pulled me away from the dead souls who were trying to take me, dark souls who had been sent my way so my organs would get sick and fail. In the prophecy delivered at my initiation ceremony, it was revealed I had been cursed since I was in my mother's womb. My father's lover – a revolting bitch – had put the

curses on me, and the new had joined forces with the old. These things work like that, mija, like chemistry. Omidina named me Omicunlé, after the cloak that covers the sea, because it was also prophesied that my followers would protect the house of Yemayá. Oh, Omidina, baba mi, it's a good thing you died and didn't have to see this."

As soon as the sun came up, Esther took Acilde over to a corner of the living room and sat down on a mat on the floor. She tucked her gray mane under a pearl-colored knitted hat. She pulled a fistful of shells from a white cotton bag. With these in her hands, she began to rub the mat with circular movements. First, she asked for clarity: "Omi tuto, ona tuto, tuto ilé, tuto owo, tuto omo, tuto laroye, tuto arikú babawa." Then she celebrated all the deities that reign over the others: "Moyugba Olofin, moyugba Olodumare, moyugba Olorun . . ." She paid homage to the religion's dead: "Ibaé bayen tonú Oluwo, babalosha, iyalosha, iworó." She paid homage to her dead masters: "Ibaé bayen tonú Lucila Figueroa Oyafunké Ibaé, Mamalala Yeyewe Ibaé, Bélgica Soriano Adache Ibaé . . ." And she paid tribute to those who'd initiated her: "Kinkamanché, to my padrino Belarminio Brito Omidina, to my oyugbona Rubén Millán, Baba Latye, Kinkamanché Oluwo Pablo Torres Casellas, Oddi Sa, Kinkamanché Oluwo Oyugbona Henry Álvarez . . ." She asked Elegguá, Oggún, Ochosi, Ibeyi, Changó, Yemayá, Orisha Oko, Olokun, Inle, Oshún, Obba and Babalú Ayé, Oyá and Obbatalá for their blessing and permission to carry out the consultation. "So there will be no death, or illness, or losses, or tragedies, or arguments, or gossip, or obstacles, and so all bad things will be kept away, and we'll receive a triumphant iré, a healthy iré, an intelligent iré, a holy iré, a wedding iré, a money iré, a progressive iré, a business iré, an iré with what comes in from the sea, an iré of open roads, an iré of freedom, a work iré, an iré that goes all the way home, an iré that comes down from heaven, a balanced iré, an iré of happiness."

Of the sixteen shells she threw on the mat, four had fallen with their mouths up. "Iroso," said Esther, which was the name of the sign on the oracle, then she lifted her face and added the sign's refrain: "Nobody knows what's at the bottom of the ocean." After throwing the shells several more times, she offered her diagnosis: "The sign is iré, which means good luck, all good. Don't cheat. Don't talk your business over with anyone, so no one knows what you're thinking or what you're going to do. Don't pass over holes or go into holes, holes in the street or holes in the countryside, because the earth will swallow you up. People like you always have jealous and hypocritical people surrounding you, as though you were a child of traps and falsehoods. You're friends with your enemy. The saint protects you from disgrace but you have to be careful and avoid prison. You'll receive inheritances and hidden riches."

Like in any good movie, Esther could make Acilde believe anything so long as she had her in front of her. As soon as she was gone, her faith would vanish too, disappearing into that world of betrayals, pacts, and dead scouts. One night, right after finishing her workout, Acilde heard a hum coming from the room where they kept the altar to Yemayá, the goddess of the sea to whom Omicunlé was devoted. Esther was sleeping. Acilde dared to go in. It smelled of incense and flower-scented water, of old fabric and the perfume of the sea held within conch shells. She approached the altar, whose centerpiece was a replica of a Greek jar some three feet tall. Eric liked to kid Esther that someday he'd inherit it; Acilde knew its exorbitant price from her PriceSpy. Depicted on the central band of the jar was an image of a woman holding a boy by the ankle as she goes to submerge him in a pool of water. All over the jar there were offerings and the attributes of the goddess: an old oar, a ship's wheel, a feathered fan. Esther had told her never to open the jar, that whoever looked inside without being initiated into the sect would go blind, or some other crazy thing like that. But inside, perfectly illuminated and oxygenated by a mechanism adapted to the jar, Acilde saw a live sea anemone. Without putting the lid back, she looked around the bottom border of the jar to find the red eye that responded to the remote control and a small hole where a battery charger would fit perfectly. That's what the old lady was doing when she "attended" to these saints: monitoring the salt levels in the tank where she kept an illegal and very valuable specimen alive. When Acilde tried to use the PriceSpy on the animal, it just loaded endlessly. It didn't work very well with black market prices.

For the first time in her life, Marta sat at the head of the table, and her sister, clean, dressed in white linen and anointed with perfumed oils, sat to her right. She brought out more wine before the carafe was empty, and without saying grace, she devoured the chicken, the fat drumsticks with crispy skin, caramelly, delicious, that had never ever been for her. She looked at María, who looked like a barbarian scraping her teeth against the chicken breast, thigh, wing, and she let out a slow laugh. The laughter of wine and freedom. Laughter that signalled no one else would again stand up from the head of the table and eat the golden fatness of the chicken and behold the beautiful María: her face dirty, her hands greasy, gripping the cup to take a long drink of wine, her mouth overflowing. Wine. A pair of libertine women. She wanted to say to María, Look at us, look at us, how unlike ourselves, so full of pleasure, today, when we should still be in mourning, today, when the house should be shrouded in black. We're alone now, my sister, more than alone – without a man in the house – and you'd think we'd be trembling like kittens that've lost their mother.

But Marta didn't say anything, just smiled. And María returned the smile with teeth covered in pieces of dark meat. They ate their fill and continued eating just to see what would happen, and, their bellies bulging, they went out into the yard with their arms around each other. The night was starry. The animals were asleep, the servants too. The entire world slept a snoring, drunken sleep. They had food, they had water, they had land, they had shelter. Marta could almost smell the sea like on holiday that one time, when their parents were alive, when he wasn't him, but just another one of them: three children running on the beach and returning every now and then, Look Mama a shell, look Papa a crab. Good times, yes – the air smelled like the good days, back when Papa didn't come home bitter, when he didn't lash out at anyone who got in his way with that thin leather switch that quietly ripped open flesh, like it was nothing, until blood sprang up like a red surprise and stung with pain. He started with Mama, moved on to their brother and then to Marta, who managed to protect María from the switch. Papa had turned them into other people, another family. Perhaps that sacred word, *family*, shouldn't even be used. Those days Papa stank, reeked of fermentation, and they hid under the bed while Mama screamed, and sometimes he traded the switch for a whip, which warned them of the coming pain with its *tchas, tchas, tchas* in the air.

Marta hugged her sister María tighter, looking at her childlike face, aged now but so pretty nonetheless, with those strange eyes, so green, so disturbing. She kissed away María's tears and told her that she loved her and asked her sister to forgive her. María knew what she meant. Then María, full of wine and chicken and total freedom, removed her dress and closed her eyes and opened her arms so that her sister could see her whole, naked, crucified. So she could see what a person is capable of doing when there's nothing to stop them. So she would understand from her scars that cruelty would always triumph over helplessness. Someone had written the word *whore* on her stomach with a sharp object, someone had stomped on her right hand until it resembled a flipper, someone had bitten her nipples until they had come loose, flaps of skin hanging from her round breasts, someone had inserted farming tools into her anus and left her haemorrhaging, someone had kicked her until she miscarried, someone, no one, had done anything they wanted for all those days that she lay there unconscious, and the rats, with their eager little teeth, had begun to nibble at her cheeks, her nose, someone, assuredly their brother, had turned her back into wicker from so many lashes. *Tchas, tchas, tchas*.

And infection, scabs, rot, blood, fractures, anaemia, venereal disease, pus, pain.

Marta knelt before her sister. She held her arms out to her and she whispered ten, thirty, a hundred times, never again, never again, never again. And Marta was sorry for being healthy, for being a virgin, for being alive. And she sobbed and spat on the ground and cursed their brother. She cursed their brother's grave, cursed his name and cursed his cock and cursed his now-rotting corpse. And hugging her sister's skinny, scabbed knees, she said:

'I have no god but you, María.'

Then the back door slammed shut and they both screamed. Damn, the wind. María put her dress back on and they went inside the house, which was suddenly as hostile and cold as a cave. As they approached the table with their candles, they realised that what looked like skin covering the scraps of chicken were dozens of brown cockroaches that started to skitter around, making a crunching sound like rasping leaves. They shrieked as if they'd seen a ghost. Marta said that at times like this – only at times like this – you need a man in the house, and María, who was standing on a chair with her skirts pulled up around her waist, started to laugh like a person possessed, and said no, that she preferred cockroaches, all the cockroaches in the world, over a man in the house. Then she jumped to the floor, and with both of her bare feet, she landed, precisely, on top of two cockroaches, one foot on each, and they popped open like little boxes and released a bright white fluid. Marta told her to quiet down, that someone might hear them, but she also laughed about how something so stupid had made them scream like that and about how her sister wasn't wearing underwear in the middle of the dining room and about how they didn't need

a man, much less *that* man, and all the while, she never stopped moving her legs and shaking out her dress in case some bug happened to climb on her, and it looked like she was dancing, and if someone had seen them – one naked from the waist down, all laughs, killing cockroaches, and the other dancing like a lunatic – they would never have thought that three days ago, just three, these women had lost their brother, their only brother.

But that's how it was.

He had been sick awhile, they said it was some illness that he'd caught in the desert. That he'd caught from some woman in the desert, María thought, but she never said it to her sister or to anyone else. She'd witnessed such things: healthy men at death's door in a matter of months, with the black shame, burned like sheaths of rice and blubbering about the devil or the sweet, sweet taste of dates in some imaginary land. María knew that her brother had died from sin, but who would believe her? *She* was the one who bore that cross, not her brother, yes, of course, her perfect brother: pure as holy water. María had a good memory: she remembered the day her brother kicked her out of the house and made her sleep out beyond the servants' quarters and the stables in a dark cowshed with half a roof. His whore sister didn't deserve to sleep on linen or embroidered silk like Marta, the good sister, the pious sister. The whore deserved to sleep with the rats, on a reeking pallet. The whore, the devil's servant, touched herself between her legs and moaned. That's what being a whore meant: taking pleasure in pleasure. He saw her. He went into her room and found María with her hand between her legs. There will be no whores in this house, he said. And that was it. That night he tied her to a water trough and under the beautiful stars he kicked open her face. When Marta came outside to beg him to have mercy on her, he raised his hand and told her that if she took one more step he would kill her. I'll do the same to you, he said, but I'll kill you. Anyone who defends a whore is also a whore, he shouted. And so Marta knelt in the dusty yard watching her brother break their sister with his blows.

Now the two women were alone. Marta had moved into their brother's room, and her old room, exquisite, had gone to María. Now it was time to spoil her, to adore her, to glorify her. Out there in the shed they'd raped her, she who had been a virgin the week before, all the servants took turns, even those who had called her 'niña María' the week before. Men, young and old, paraded through. There, on top of her, the town's sexuality came to life and died. There, they abused her and penetrated her anus and her vagina, and he tortured her, he who called himself pure, who called himself a man of God, who was the dear friend of the most holy of holy men, the man who'd been fawned over when he came to the house and who'd had his dusty, calloused feet washed by María with her own divine, exotic perfumed oils.

Marta knew all this because one night she had followed and watched, her eyes shining with fear. And afterwards, whenever she closed her eyes, she saw them again and again. Brother on top of sister. María like a dead body, her eyes closed, rocked by the inertia of his movement, like a white corpse – a fly buzzing around her mouth, her eyes, her nostrils – still stained with blood, and him, looking all around like a criminal, stealing back to the main house in the moonlight, his cock stained with the same blood. Did María have her period? Or was she so destroyed that inside she was just an open wound? Neither heaven nor earth was ever the same again. Brother on top of sister, like in the darkest of horrors.

This went on for many, many nights.

The pallet on which her sister lay – half-dead, barely alive – was a filthy heap where maggots bred, and which some men, even though it was free, even though it was easy, found too repulsive. A rotting body, disgusting, stinking. María, sweet beautiful María, her eyes like precious stones from distant mountains, daughter of the sea and the desert, was now too disgusting for the filthiest of strangers. Sometimes, some desperate man would throw a bucket of water on her and just like that, all wet, he'd take care not to touch her too much as he penetrated her quickly, violently, like a goat.

Marta couldn't care for her sister. The walls had eyes and mouths and tongues like serpents. They would tell him immediately and he would do the same to her: he'd put them both, one next to the other, on the same pallet, in the same hell. Marta gave a coin to some maid to take a bucket of water and a sponge to wash her sister's bruised, grey and bloody body, but she never knew if she actually did it. But she had to have faith. Faith in the maid. Faith that the servant would give her a piece of fish, some bread and milk. Faith that the guard would, for enough money, stop every man in town from using her. At least for those few days of the month. At least on the holy days. At least today. Faith that the messenger boy would give her sister the note telling her to hang on, *the two of us will leave this place soon*. But it was just faith, the most pathetic of feelings. Faith didn't do a goddamn thing. For example, when their brother's friend, the holiest of holy men, visited, he asked after María and her eyes like rare gems, and though excuses were made to deflect his requests, he kept asking after María and her eyes of an otherworldly green, so their brother had no choice but to take him to the filthy shed where he had her bound, half-naked and stained with excrement, spread open in a posture more vile than that of a butchered animal – that man, the holiest of holy men, began to cry and shout and plead and shake their brother, saying, No one can forgive you for what you've done here, untie her right now, you insane, sadistic bastard. But their brother just said, She is a sinner, Father, she is the most sinful of all women. I have seen her. She takes pleasure in the sins of the flesh, Father. I wasn't told this. I had the misfortune of witnessing it, Father, she is repugnant. And if I untie her, Father, then others will think that this can be done without consequences, that it can be this way, and

I won't allow it.

And then the man, whose feet María had washed with her own hair, knelt down and prayed for her awhile, a few minutes, and went into the house to have dinner and drinks with the men. As he was leaving, after embracing him, he told their brother: You should untie her. His voice sounded teary, maybe drunk. And their brother, nodding his head a lot, looking down, said, Yes, Father, I will do as you wish. Marta walked out to meet the holy man, and she knelt: Please. It is your brother's house, he responded to Marta, and I can't impose my will upon him, respect for a man is shown through respect for his home, but I have already told him that he should untie her, and I will pray for it to be so. You should have faith, he told Marta before disappearing into the desert, *faith*.

The word tasted like shit on her tongue.

And María remained in the shed.

When their brother got sick, Marta – whom everyone praised for her dedication, her deference, her devotion, her broths, her tenderness, her herbal infusions – cared for him. She fed him, cleaned him, gave him medicine, and even applied a white ointment to his private parts, which burned bright red. But everything that an observer would have interpreted as affection, she carried out with a deep hatred. To the outside eye, Marta was all delicacy, but alone she fed him cold, gelatinous broth, always with a dash of fresh manure, sand, or maggots that she found in the yard and stowed in a box to mix with his food, careful that no one saw. When she washed her brother's body, which had become one huge, bloody, purple wound oozing with pus, she began gently, with warm water, coconut oil, and a sea sponge, but suddenly, without warning, without any changes to her breathing, she became violent. Marta switched the sea sponge for steel wool and scraped his arms up and down like she was sanding wood. She finished her polishing with rubbing alcohol. She was imaginative: she'd pour hot wax or camphor on his wounds, stinging nettle or lemon. Then she'd leave the room and sit on a chair beside the door, her hands crossed in her lap piously, and her eyes closed tight, while inside her brother writhed in pain and made horrific sounds, muted because he could no longer scream: the illness had taken his tongue, and in its place had left a kind of red mush that wiggled around his toothless mouth like some lascivious monster.

Anyone who had seen Marta would have thought she was praying for the health of her sick brother, but she was praying for him to die slowly, as painfully as possible.

And one day he died. It wasn't quick or easy: his gruesome death throes lasted hours. He was thirsty and no one gave him water. Marta closed the doors and windows, and as if it were a show, she sat watching him die. She let him agonise alone, although her brother held out his skeletal hand to her, perhaps begging for company, contact: for her to put her living hand, like a little dove, over his almost-dead hand, for her to wash away his sweat and drip just a few tears onto his forehead, two tiny diamonds, which he might use to pay whatever waited for him on the other side of death. The dying will cry, moan, writhe: they fear that everything they know about heaven and hell is all a lie. Or rather, the truth.

When the man finally went still, his mouth agape and eyes wide as if he'd just heard some hilarious joke, Marta slowly stood up, opened the door, walked through the rooms of the house, went out into the yard, and theatrically threw herself on the ground and screamed and screamed until all the neighbours came. She covered her face with her hands, but there were no tears. She was radiant like a celestial body. María heard her sister's screams, and her heart froze. Then she closed her eyes, crusted over, and opened them again very slowly, like a newborn. And like a newborn, she began to wail, calling to her sister.

Four days later, just four, their brother's friend, the holy man, arrived in town, and then Marta had to pretend, to wail no, no, no, and cry her tearless cry for her dead brother. If only you had been here, she told him because she couldn't think of anything else to say. If only you had been here. But she knew those words were as ridiculous as condolences, as a prayer. What was, was. What is, is. Then the friend, the holy man, asked her to take him to the crypt, and there she left him, kneeling, calling to the dead man like someone calls at the door of a house, as if on the other side of the stone there was still some life left in him to hear.

Marta shrugged her shoulders at such an absurd display and went back to her house, to the party for her liberated sister, to life.

That night, as Marta and María ate lamb, they were startled by a banging on the door. It must be the wind. The wind this time of year, terrible. Marta and María continued eating until they heard the door groan, and raised their heads to watch it swing inward as if pushed by a hand. It opened.

First the flies appeared, and immediately after, their dead brother, shrouded in a nauseating smell. He opened and closed his mouth, as if calling out their names, but no sound fell from that toothless gap, only maggots.

2002

Without removing his sunglasses, El Gordo began moving his huge hands across the synth keyboard.

I'll sing you a corrido
A tale I know by heart

With little flourishes, dancing fingers.

Of Tatahuicapa bonito
A town torn right apart

And Agustín moved his head next to the speaker, as did Jacobo, the taxi driver who drove us to see El Gordo – also known as Armando Terán – to witness his 'Digital Magic', as the sign above his front door advertised. We'd talked ourselves into going to the musician's house, having spent an entire afternoon marooned in sad old Villa Isla looking for the investigation file on the lynching. Jacobo drove us in his taxi to the centre of Playa Vicente and convinced El Gordo to play us that ballad, written in the late nineties by someone called Panuncio Mendoza.

A rapist and a killer, oh,
He pays for his black heart

From Veracruz to Tuxepec, and from there to Playa Vicente and then to Isla, and back to Playa, without finding any records, not a single document, just hearsay about the burned man of Tatahuicapa.

1996

The town of La Unión Progreso Tatahuicapa, Veracruz. Population: 236 people.

On August thirty-first
A town in shock and wincing

A bright, sultry Saturday. The river's waters were crystal clear. It was a sight for sore eyes, made you want to dive in. 'Maybe later,' a lot of people thought on their way to work. Maybe after the assembly on the town's sports fields.

Unleased an angry outburst:
The Tatahuicapa lynching

A group of houses at the bottom of a hill. A dirt pitch, a church, mango trees.

The townsfolk did their worst
And burned him without flinching

The men, on horseback. The women, huddled. All of them on the same rocky track.

2002

From Playa we took the bus to Cosamaloapan, to the Morelos prison, past the Papaloapan River – river of butterflies – and hundreds of hectares of pineapple, banana and sugar cane plantations. We were looking for the court file for criminal case number 201-96, which the official in Villa Isla had told us about, and which supposedly we'd find among the prison court records. We were also keen to see the video: the one that had been broadcast on the local news and had influenced the state authorities to detain half the town in order to find the responsible parties, the torturers of that man who, dressed only in a pair of red underpants, was burned alive tied to a tree. We wanted to see the legal file, the autopsy, the photos, all of it. We wanted to feel like detectives for the weekend. We were all geared up to interview the lynchers, to talk to them and ask them why they did it.

'When the lynching happened,' began Ramírez Cepeda, an official from the Cosmaloapan Public Prosecutor's Office, 'Tatahuicapa was an inaccessible community. Even the authorities found out what had happened from the famous video.' The official proceeded to tell us all about the time he accompanied a police force to resolve a matter in the municipality of Xochiapa, which used to count the town of Tatahuicapa within its jurisdiction. 'As soon as we arrived the church bells started ringing and people came running at us. Christ, even with guns we felt like we were being overpowered.' According to Ramírez Cepeda, the area's ungovernability was mostly down to the influence of the local bosses, who stood to gain from areas like it becoming independent – it gave them more control, which meant they could make more money. 'But what will those people do once they gain independence, beyond starve to death? What they really want is to undermine the government. When the roads are opened, the authorities can get in, but there are some heads that are never going to fall. Not long ago there was a case in this area where two hundred kilos of marijuana was intercepted and seized... then half of it went missing on its way to the Public Prosecutor's Office. We're talking top-level corruption. You get the call saying "keep out of it", and, well...' Ramírez Cepeda shrugged his shoulders. 'And at the end of the day, what did I have to do with it? It was a matter for the feds.'

'Does machete law rule in these parts?' Agustín asked him.

'More like *cuerno de chivo* law,' smirked the public officer, clasping his belt buckle and showing it to us: on it, set against the outline of a marijuana leaf, was the relief of a goat's horn, or *cuerno de chivo*: the colloquial name for an AK-47.

Someone was ringing the church bells. A distorted voice crackled from the loudspeakers hanging from the trees, and the sound filtered into the houses through open windows, animal pens and holes in the concrete blocks. 'They've taken Doña Anita!' some women were screaming, scared to death, on their way back along the dirt path from the river.

Twenty-eight years old
Was young Rodolfo Soler

Alarmed by the commotion, the men – who'd just returned from the fields and were either eating lunch in their houses, or down on the town's sports pitch waiting for the monthly assembly to discuss the town's communal lands – ran down to the river, machetes in hand. Dozens of faces could be seen peeping out from behind the undergrowth on the river's edge. Hands and fingers were pointing towards someone in the water, a man with the eyes of a terrified child, eyes fixed on the knives and clubs being brandished in his direction by furious onlookers, who were frantic because he was still holding Señora Ana María Borromeo by the hair, even as she floated face-down on the surface, not far from the clothes she'd intended to wash that morning.

Women, girls, young or old
He didn't seem to care

Soler was known to the community as a cattle thief, rapist and marijuana fiend. He had been arrested on several occasions but was always released by the authorities. The day they caught him next to the body of Doña Anita they beat him all the way to the town sports field, where the men tied him to a tree with a nylon rope and proceeded to interrogate him, giving him electric shocks until they'd singed all the hairs on his legs, in an effort to force a confession out of him.

They were there for hours, until the authorities showed up: the secretary of Playa Vicente's Public Prosecutor's Office, the commander of the municipality's judicial police and ten armed heavies. The whole town had congregated there, most of them women and children, shouting: 'Lynch him! Kill him! Burn him so he can't get out again! So he can't come back to do worse! Burn him or our daughters can't go out alone. Or he'll be back to rape more women.'

The authorities went to the home of Genaro Avendaño, Ana María's husband, intending to take him to identify the body, but the family wouldn't even let them see him. The officers returned to the field to take Soler away, but the town had already made up their minds. They told the authorities from Playa Vicente they weren't going to hand over Rodolfo Soler; instead they'd bring him to justice themselves, and lynch him. And despite no one in Tatahuicapa being in possession of a firearm, the commander of the judicial police from Playa Vicente decided that the most prudent thing would be to leave them to do as they wished and leave. 'I haven't come here to impose any law on this town,' says the commander in a video filmed by a local named Cástulo Martínez on a video recorder he'd bought in the US. 'If the town wants to hand him over to me, I'll take him. If not, let them decide for themselves what to do. I'll leave it like that.' Liberio Contreras, the local officer, nervously addressed the crowd and asked what they wanted to do: 'Listen up, you lot, you've said "we're going to do this" and "here's what we're going to do", and you're fully within your rights... So listen, my colleagues and I, we've done our part, and the town's made a choice, so we can't very well deny you that choice, can we? Even if that's what the law says... So, are you going to lynch him or not?'

'Kill him!' the people in the video cry. 'Rapist, murderer! Criminal! Kill the piece of shit!'

'I didn't see them take him to the graveyard,' Bartolo Avendaño would later state, 'because I was busy keeping watch over my wife's body – I had to arrange the coffin and the wake. I'd asked them to kill him, I shouted that he should be burned, because they wouldn't let me near the tree they'd tied him to. They just told me not to worry, they'd do as I'd asked.'

Afterwards they drew up a popular justice ruling in which Rodolfo Soler was accused and sentenced in accordance with internal *ejido* by-laws, which demanded 'either the expulsion or execution of criminals, depending on their crime'. The ruling concludes with a warning to those 'higher authorities who allow themselves to be bribed for a few pesos', and an old Mexican historical slogan typically found on documents to be signed by public officials: 'Effective suffrage. No re-election,' followed by the signatures of Tatahuicapa's 154 adult residents.

For his crimes he paid tenfold
They burned him over there

By then, Soler was already so severely beaten he couldn't even lift his chin from his chest. The crowd dragged him towards the cemetery. Genaro Borromeo Robles (Ana María's brother) tied him with barbed wire to an evergreen oak. Hipólito Borromeo Soler, nephew to the deceased and Tatahuicapa's *topil* (or unofficial 'sheriff', the only townsperson to carry a firearm, a sawn-off .22 calibre shotgun), took down the man's trousers and tied them around his head, covering his face; next he poured a two-litre can of petrol over him. Finally, Bulmaro Avendaño, Ana María's stepson, came forward and lit the matches with which they proceeded to set alight the murderer.

'I did it out of anger,' Bulmaro would tell the Public Prosecutor, 'I was angry that this person had committed other crimes and kept being released from jail. That's why I decided to take matters into my own hands.'

Soler screamed for a couple of minutes. In the half hour that followed, he merely moaned. Once he'd fallen

to the floor they cut off his left foot with a machete to see if he was still alive, and since he continued groaning, they poured another can of fuel over him.

2009

Tatahuicapa: the ass end of Veracruz, we thought, looking at the map. Three hours to Tuxtepec from the city, another on the low-cost bus to Playa Vicente, then two hours of dirt roads to reach the village. Thirteen years after the double crime. Military checkpoints all over the place.

So listen up, young men
For the paths they truly differ

No one wants to take us down to the river. The women look at us accusingly with their black eyes. Everyone around here is related, so they know not to go around shooting their mouths off. We remember what Ramírez Cepeda, the official from the Cosmaloapan Public Prosecutor's Office, the one with the goat horn on his buckle, said to us: 'Don't stick your noses where they're not wanted, kids. Haven't you seen the film *Canoa*?'

You know now what can happen,
The cruel blow that fate delivers

In Tatahuicapa's graveyard, a boy points to a wooden cross and a vague point in the distance near some trees. And that's when we realize: barely fifteen metres separate Ana María Borromeo's grave from Soler's stake, the charred evergreen oak to which he was tied and burned alive.

No way to make amends
For my rapist, my killer.

Now that you live with complete security,
now that you have rid yourselves of all your enemies,
finally, of all your enemies,
now,
you have no idea how to handle your weakness,
your lust for suffering,
your guilt,
your desires,
your meanness
and your insults.
After the massacre is over, the question becomes:
what does man do to continue to show,
to show himself,
that he is still a man?

— Angélica Liddell

Ahora que vivís completamente seguros,
ahora que os han librado de todos los enemigos,
por fin, de todos los enemigos,
ahora,
no sabéis cómo administrar vuestra debilidad,
vuestra avidez de sufrimiento,
vuestra culpa,
vuestros deseos,
vuestra ruindad
y vuestros insultos.
La cuestión es, después de la matanza,
¿qué hace el hombre para seguir demostrando,
demostrándose a sí mismo,
que sigue siendo un hombre?

Maravilloso Reading Group was
conceived by Ros del Olmo and Ire

Organisational support by argos
centre for audiovisual arts

quote on cover by Sayak Valencia

31/08/2025
Brussels